Newcomer Families' Access to and Use of Child Care Support Resources in Toronto

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Research Methodology

I will use a qualitative methodology to explore how newcomer families at one Toronto child care centre learn about, understand, and use or do not use the family support resources that the centre offers or refers families to. In this study, family support resources are services such as the City of Toronto child care fee subsidy, EarlyON, and settlement services, which families can access through the centre's information or referrals. Qualitative research studies a small number of participants in depth so that the researcher can gather detailed accounts of one central phenomenon (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). This depth suits my central question, which asks how newcomer families describe their experiences of accessing and using or not using these resources. A family's path to a resource has many small steps, such as reading a notice, asking an educator, or deciding that a form is too hard. A count of how many families applied for a fee subsidy could show what families did, but it could not show how they understood the information, who helped them, or why they stopped at a particular step. Open conversations can bring out these details, which are what my central question asks about.

Context is the second reason for this choice. Qualitative researchers pay close attention to the context that shapes participants' experiences (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). For the families in this study, this context includes how the centre shares information about resources, whether that information is available in a language they read, which referrals staff make, and what each application asks families to provide. Families meet these conditions in different languages and after different migration journeys. These conditions shape access, so I will describe them alongside the families' accounts. Because parents describe this context in their own words, it can still be collected in an interview on Zoom or by phone, although these formats

offer fewer non-verbal cues than meeting in person. To reduce this limitation, I will ask parents to describe specific moments, such as reading a notice or filling out a form, so that their accounts include the context of each step.

The third reason is meaning-making. Grounded in constructivism, qualitative research seeks to understand how people make meaning of their social realities (Mwita, 2022). This matters because newcomer parents' perspectives are often not accounted for in research or in the way services are planned and explained, and terms such as eligibility or waitlist may mean something different to a parent than to an educator. How a family interprets such information shapes whether it uses a resource. Open-ended interview questions will let me hear how each family makes sense of eligibility rules and educators' explanations and how it reaches a decision. Families may understand the same rules in different ways, and these differences will add depth to the data.

Research Design

I will use a qualitative descriptive design. Qualitative description aims to give a full summary of events in the everyday language of the people who experienced them (Sandelowski, 2000). Researchers who use this design stay close to participants' words and keep interpretation low, so the findings reflect what participants actually said. The design also studies experiences in their natural setting, without variables or a theory chosen in advance (Hall & Liebenberg, 2024).

This design fits my study for three reasons. First, qualitative description reports events in the words of the people who experienced them (Sandelowski, 2000), so I can organize my interview protocol around the steps families take with a resource, from hearing about it to deciding whether to use it. My sub-questions ask families what helped or limited them, who explained the steps, and how educators responded to their language and cultural needs. Because

the analysis will stay close to what parents say, I can organize the findings along the same steps, so each part of the findings answers one of these questions directly. Second, qualitative description suits studies that need information directly from the people affected and that have limited time and resources (Hall & Liebenberg, 2024). A single-centre student project completed within one term fits that description. Third, findings that stay close to participants' words can inform practice (Villamin et al., 2025). Educators at the centre could use them to see where their explanations and referrals help families and where they fall short. Ilumin (2023) used the same design to describe immigrant families' child care experiences in Edmonton.

Participants, Recruitment and Sampling Plan

Participants and Recruitment

The participants will be four newcomer parents or primary caregivers. I define a newcomer family as an immigrant or refugee family with young children that has lived in Canada for five years or less (Massing et al., 2024). Each participant must (a) be 18 or older, (b) have arrived in Canada within the past five years, in any immigration category, (c) have a child enrolled at the study centre, (d) have received information about, or a referral to, at least one family support service from the centre in the past 12 months, such as the City of Toronto child care fee subsidy, EarlyON, or settlement services, and (e) be able to take part in English or Mandarin, or with an interpreter.

These criteria select parents with direct and recent experience with accessing and utilizing the resources my questions ask about. Criterion (d) includes parents whether or not they went on to use the resource, because my research question asks about both using and not using resources. I will explore each family's account on its own terms. The study will not divide families into users and non-users, and it will not compare them.

I will exclude families I have worked with in the past, including families from the room where I completed my placement, and families of centre staff. My earlier role, or a parent's employment at the centre, could make these families feel obliged to take part or less willing to speak critically about the centre (Villamin et al., 2025). Because I define newcomers by their time in Canada, eligibility will not depend on immigration category. Permanent residents, refugees and refugee claimants, parents with work or study permits, and parents who became citizens within the past five years will all be eligible, because immigration status can affect eligibility for services such as the fee subsidy, for example through tax-filing requirements (Toronto Children's Services, 2025), and these differences are part of what families experience. I will also not ask about immigration status. Fee subsidy applications require tax documents that undocumented families often cannot provide (Schmidt, 2026), and questions about status could discourage families from joining.

Recruitment Setting

I will recruit at a licensed child care centre in the Parkdale neighbourhood of west Toronto, where I completed my field placement. To protect families' privacy, I will not name the centre in this proposal or in any report. I chose this setting for two reasons. The centre already offers and refers family support resources, so its families have the experiences my questions ask about. Toronto's service plan also names child care settings as access points and identifies tax-filing requirements as a barrier to fee subsidy (Toronto Children's Services, 2025). A study in one centre can show how these city policies reach families. My placement gives me access to the centre, which makes recruitment feasible within the course timeline.

Recruitment Methods

I will first obtain approval from the George Brown Polytechnic Research Ethics Board (Canadian Institutes of Health Research et al., 2022) and written permission from the centre director. I will not contact any family before both are in place. I will then prepare a one-page flyer and a letter of information in plain English and translate them into Mandarin and other languages common at the centre. The materials will explain the purpose of the study, the total time of about 60 to 75 minutes in one meeting, the voluntary nature of taking part, the $25 gift card, and how to reach me. The $25 gift card recognizes the 60 to 75 minutes that the meeting asks of each parent. TCPS 2 asks researchers to consider participants' economic circumstances so that an incentive does not become an undue inducement (Canadian Institutes of Health Research et al., 2022), and Head (2009) notes that payment in qualitative research can recognize participants' time while also raising concerns about influence on consent. I chose a modest amount for this reason, and the card will not depend on completing the interview, since parents who skip questions or stop early will still receive it. The Research Ethics Board will also review the amount before recruitment begins.

The director will share the invitation through the parent newsletter, the notice board, and family cubbies, and staff will not approach families in person. As in Hardware et al. (2026), someone other than the lead researcher will distribute the invitation to avoid a conflict of interest. A notice from the director could still feel like a request from the centre. The flyer will therefore state that the centre will not know who takes part and that the decision will not affect any child's care. Interested parents will contact me directly by email, phone, or text. A 10-minute call will confirm eligibility, and parents will have at least 48 hours to decide after they receive the consent

form. If fewer than four parents respond by the middle of Week 1, the director will send one reminder.

Sampling Plan

Sampling Strategy. I will use purposive sampling, in which the researcher intentionally selects people who can help to understand the central phenomenon (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). Here, that means newcomer parents who have received information about, or a referral to, a family support service from the centre. The sample will also be a convenience sample, because I will recruit willing and available parents at a centre I can already reach (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). The purposive criteria decide who is eligible, and convenience explains where I will find them. Neither method aims to represent all newcomer families. Together, they reach parents who can give detailed accounts of accessing and using resources through this centre.

Participant Selection. Parents will contact me voluntarily, and I will screen each one in the 10-minute eligibility call using the inclusion and exclusion criteria. The centre will not take part in screening or selection and will not be told who responded. Eligible parents will receive the letter of information and consent form in their preferred language before they decide. I will select the first four eligible parents who agree to take part. Only one adult from each family will take part. If more than four eligible parents respond, I will place the others on a waitlist in order of contact and invite them in turn if a participant withdraws before the interview.

Sample Size. I will include four participants. Qualitative studies commonly use about four to eight participants so that the researcher can explore each person’s experience in detail (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). Four participants also match the course requirement for

individual projects. The findings will describe these four families' experiences and will not be generalized to all newcomer families.

Data Collection

Procedure

I will collect data through individual, semi-structured, in-depth interviews. The interview is my data collection method, and an interview protocol is my tool. The protocol will list open-ended questions with follow-up probes, and its flexible order will let me ask for more detail when a parent raises something new. I chose individual interviews over focus groups because income and subsidy are sensitive topics and families at one centre may know one another (Villamin et al., 2025). Before Week 1, I will pilot the protocol with one newcomer parent from outside the study to check its wording, translation, and length.

Each participant will take part in one meeting of about 60 to 75 minutes at a time the family chooses. Families can meet in a private room at the centre outside drop-off and pick-up times, on Zoom, or by phone. Those who join online may turn off the camera and use a pseudonym, as in Hardware et al. (2026). I will interview Mandarin speakers myself. For other languages, a trained interpreter who signs a confidentiality agreement will join, so that meaning is not lost in translation (Ilumin, 2023). Each meeting will follow three steps:

1. Consent (about 10 minutes). I will go through the letter of information in the parent's language and answer any questions. The parent will then sign the consent form or give recorded verbal consent.
2. Background form (about 5 minutes). The parent will note years in Canada, children's ages, home language, and the services the centre shared information about or referred them to. The form will not ask about immigration status or income.

3. Interview (45 to 60 minutes). With permission, I will audio record the interview. The questions will follow the steps families take toward a resource. Parents will describe how they learned about a resource and what they understood about eligibility and applying. They will explain who helped them, such as educators, settlement workers, or relatives, and what that help involved. They will talk about what led them to use or not use the resource. Finally, they will describe whether they could raise needs linked to their language and culture, how educators responded, and what they would suggest the centre change. At the end, each parent will receive the $25 gift card and a list of community supports such as EarlyON and 211 Toronto.

Taking part is voluntary. Parents may skip any question or stop the interview at any time and will still receive the gift card. They may withdraw their data within one week after their interview. I will not begin coding an interview until that participant's withdrawal period has ended. Their child's care will not be affected either way. I will remove names, use pseudonyms, and keep recordings and transcripts in encrypted, password-protected files stored apart from the consent forms. Only I will hold the list that links pseudonyms to names. A small sample from one centre can make people identifiable, so my reports will not combine details such as country of origin and home language. I will also change or leave out any quotation that could identify a family (Villamin et al., 2025).

Timeline of Research Study

Table 1

Timeline of the Research Study

Period	Research activity	Main tasks
By December 2026	Ethics and preparation	Obtain ethics approval and the director's permission, translate materials, and pilot the interview protocol
Weeks 1 and 2	Recruit participants	Share the invitation, send one reminder if needed, screen parents, obtain consent, and schedule interviews
Weeks 2 and 3	Collect data	Begin interviews in Week 2, complete at least three of four (75%) by the end of Week 3, and transcribe each one soon after it ends
Week 4	Complete data collection	Conduct the last interview and begin initial coding
Week 5	Preliminary findings	Submit a summary of preliminary findings
Weeks 6 and 7	Complete analysis	Complete semantic-level thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2022) and submit the findings report by Week 7
Weeks 8 and 9	Refine findings	Review and refine the findings using feedback
Week 10	Presentation draft	Complete a draft of the presentation
Weeks 11 to 13	Revise	Revise the presentation and the final report
Week 14	Final submission	Submit the final report

Ethics approval must be in place before the term begins, because recruitment starts in Week 1 and interviews begin in Week 2. I will transcribe each interview soon after it ends and start coding in Week 4, so the preliminary findings will be ready in Week 5. Throughout the study, I will record decisions, changes, and challenges in my reflexive journal.

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